

COMPLETE REFERENCE GUIDE

The Canadian Surrogacy Roadmap

Your complete step-by-step guide from first question to bringing baby home.

Includes: journey timeline, budget tracker, surrogate questions guide, legal prep, clinic checklist, and fillable worksheets.

Robyn Price

Executive Director, Canadian Surrogacy Options

In this field since I was four years old.

What's inside this guide

PART 1 **Welcome & How to Use This Guide**

PART 2 **Is Surrogacy Right For You?**

The honest questions to ask yourself

PART 3 **Understanding the Canadian Framework**

Legal overview, provincial differences, altruistic model explained

PART 4 **Your Complete Journey Timeline**

All 8 phases mapped with timeframes – 12 steps

PART 5 **Building Your Professional Team**

Who you need and what they do

PART 6 **Finding and Matching With a Surrogate**

What to look for, questions to ask your match

PART 7 **The Legal Agreement Deep-Dive**

What must be in your agreement

PART 8 **The Complete Budget Tracker**

Full fillable cost planner

PART 9 **Clinic and Medical Guide**

Screening, transfers, what to expect

PART 10 **The Pregnancy and Birth**

Staying connected, birth preparation

PART 11 **After the Birth**

Parentage, passports, closing the journey

Welcome & How to Use This Guide

You are holding the most comprehensive guide to Canadian surrogacy that exists outside of a lawyer's office. I know that's a big claim. But I have been in this field since I was four years old, and I built this guide because I was tired of watching families navigate one of the most important journeys of their lives with incomplete, confusing, or commercially biased information.

This roadmap covers everything. From the first honest questions you should ask yourself, through matching, legal agreements, the pregnancy, the birth, and the weeks after. Every phase has a detailed guide and the worksheet section at the back gives you fillable tools to use throughout.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Read it in order the first time. Then use individual sections as reference as you move through your journey. The worksheets are designed to be printed and filled in by hand, or typed into directly.

A note on independence: This guide is written to be useful whether you are working with a full-service agency, doing an independent journey, or somewhere in between. Where steps differ based on your situation, I will call that out clearly.

"Every family deserves to move forward with clarity, confidence, and the right information by their side - not the version filtered through someone else's commercial interest."

Is Surrogacy Right For You?

Before anything else, these are the honest questions worth sitting with. There are no wrong answers – just important ones.

Do you have a clear medical or personal reason?

Surrogacy is pursued for many valid reasons – medical necessity, same-sex family building, single parenthood, and more. You do not need to justify your reason to anyone. But clarity about your *why* will carry you through the harder moments.

Are you financially prepared?

Canadian surrogacy typically costs \$60,000 to \$150,000 CAD. Not having the full amount upfront is common – but going in significantly under-resourced creates serious risk. Understand your financial picture before you begin.

Are you emotionally ready to share this journey?

Your surrogate will be deeply involved in one of the most intimate experiences of your life. The families who do best approach this as a relationship, not a transaction.

Do you have support around you?

A partner, trusted friends, a therapist, or a community. Surrogacy journeys have high points and hard points. You should not face either alone.

Can you handle uncertainty and longer timelines?

Matching can take months. Transfers sometimes fail. Timelines slip. The families who navigate this most gracefully are those who went in knowing it could be long.

Understanding the Canadian Framework

Canada has one of the clearest legal frameworks for surrogacy in the world. Here is what you need to understand before you start.

The Assisted Human Reproduction Act (AHRA)

- Altruistic surrogacy is legal across Canada.
- Commercial surrogacy – paying a surrogate a fee or wage – is prohibited.
- Surrogates can be reimbursed for documented, pregnancy-related expenses.
- A surrogacy agreement must be in place before any embryo transfer.
- Both parties must have independent legal counsel.
- The agreement is not automatically legally enforceable in all provinces – a parentage order from the court is what legally establishes parenthood.

Provincial Differences

PROVINCE / REGION	SURROGACY RECOGNISED?	NOTES
Ontario	Yes	Strong framework. Most IPs from other provinces use ON surrogates.
British Columbia	Yes	Clear Parentage Act. Straightforward process.
Alberta	Yes	Generally smooth. Consult a local surrogacy lawyer.
Manitoba / Saskatchewan	Possible	Varies. Independent legal advice essential.
Quebec	No	Civil Code does not recognise surrogacy agreements. Use a surrogate in another province.
Atlantic provinces	Varies	Check with a surrogacy lawyer licensed in the relevant province.
International IPs in Canada	Varies	Additional steps for citizenship / passport. Your lawyer guides this.

The Altruistic Model - What Is Allowed

ALLOWED	NOT ALLOWED
Reimbursement for pregnancy-related medications	A base salary or monthly wage for being a surrogate
Travel costs to medical appointments (mileage, parking, transit)	Payment in exchange for the surrogacy itself
Lost wages for mandatory medical appointments	Bonuses tied to successful transfer or birth
Maternity clothing allowance	Paying surrogacy expenses directly in cash without receipts
Life and disability insurance premiums	Compensation for pain, discomfort, or emotional labour
Childcare during appointments	Anything that could be characterised as commercial surrogacy

Your Complete Journey Timeline

Here is the full surrogacy journey mapped from start to finish. Timeframes are realistic averages – your journey may be faster or slower. Use this as a planning reference, not a guarantee.

01

WEEKS 1–4

Choose your agency or independent path

Research agencies, check references, ask hard questions. If going independent, confirm your surrogate is genuinely ready and meets eligibility criteria.

02

WEEKS 3–8

Complete intake and build your IP profile

Your agency or your own process: complete intake forms, gather medical history, write your IP profile. This is what surrogates will review when considering a match.

03

MONTHS 1–24

Surrogate matching

The most variable phase. With a priority program: 4–9 months average. With a standard program: 12–24 months. Independent journey with known surrogate: parallel to intake.

04

WEEKS 1–4 AFTER MATCH

Psychological screening

Both surrogate and IPs complete psychological evaluation with a registered professional. Required by most clinics. Surrogates must pass this before medical screening begins.

05

WEEKS 2–8 AFTER MATCH

Medical screening

Surrogate completes full medical screening at your fertility clinic. Uterine assessment, bloodwork, infectious disease screening. Do not move to legal until clearance is confirmed.

06

WEEKS 4–10 AFTER CLEARANCE

Legal agreements

Both parties retain independent lawyers. Agreement is drafted, reviewed, and signed. Allow at least 4–6 weeks. Do not rush. No transfer until this is signed.

07

MONTH 1 AFTER AGREEMENT

Embryo transfer

Surrogate completes a mock or medicated transfer cycle. Embryo transfer takes place. Most families do 1–3 transfer cycles before a positive result.

08

MONTH 2 AFTER TRANSFER

Confirmed pregnancy

Positive beta HCG confirmed, then first ultrasound at 6–8 weeks. Transition to OB/GYN care after 10–12 weeks.

09

MONTHS 3–11

Pregnancy

Regular OB appointments, anatomy scan at 18–20 weeks, third trimester check-ins. Communication and relationship maintenance throughout.

10

WEEKS 34–40

Birth preparation

Hospital notified, birth plan filed, pre-birth order filed (6–8 weeks before due date in applicable provinces), IPs arrange travel and accommodation.

11

WEEKS 38–42

Birth

IPs present at birth. Hospital staff briefed. Post-birth paperwork begins immediately. Celebrate.

12

WEEKS 1–8 POST-BIRTH

Legal parentage and homecoming

Birth certificate, parentage order, passport if needed. Final expense reimbursements processed. Journey complete.

Building Your Professional Team

These are the professionals you will need, what they do, and when to engage them. Building the right team early is one of the highest-leverage things you can do.

Surrogacy Agency

Engage at the start

Coordinates matching, supports both parties, manages process. Optional but significantly reduces stress and improves outcomes.

Reproductive Lawyer (IPs)

Before medical screening

Drafts and negotiates surrogacy agreement, obtains parentage order. Must be licensed in the province where the surrogate lives.

Independent Lawyer (Surrogate)

Before medical screening

Reviews and advises on the surrogacy agreement independently. You pay for this. Do not use the same lawyer as the IPs.

Fertility Clinic

Confirm before matching

Medically screens surrogate, manages embryo transfer, handles all clinical coordination. You need this confirmed before matching begins.

Registered Psychologist

After match

Performs psychological evaluation of surrogate and IPs. Required by most clinics. Must have reproductive medicine experience.

OB/GYN

Engage month 3

Manages the pregnancy after the first trimester. Your surrogate may have her own or you find one together.

Life Insurance Broker

During legal phase

Secures life and disability insurance for the surrogate. Confirm surrogacy is covered before transfer.

Financial Advisor / Accountant

During financial setup

Optional but useful for managing trust accounts, cross-border payments, and tax implications.

Finding and Matching With a Surrogate

The match is the heart of your journey. Here is what to look for and what to ask.

What Makes a Strong Surrogate Match

Medical eligibility

At least one previous successful pregnancy and birth. Age 21–45. Healthy BMI. No current significant medical conditions.

Lifestyle alignment

Non-smoker, no recreational drug use, low-risk lifestyle. Willingness to follow medical protocols during the pregnancy.

Values compatibility

Aligned views on selective reduction, termination in case of medical necessity, and multi-fetal pregnancies. This conversation must happen before matching.

Communication style

Your surrogate does not need to be your best friend. But you need to be able to communicate openly and honestly throughout the pregnancy.

Support system

A stable home environment, a supportive partner or family, and access to emotional support. Her wellbeing during the pregnancy matters.

Motivation

The best surrogates are motivated by genuine desire to help a family – not primarily by financial need. Ask her why she wants to do this.

Questions to Ask Your Surrogate Match

- Why do you want to be a surrogate?
- What does your partner / support person think about this?
- Have you talked to your children about what surrogacy means?
- Have you been a surrogate before? If so, how was that experience?

ABOUT VALUES AND HARD DECISIONS

- How do you feel about selective reduction if multiple embryos implant?
- What are your views on termination if a serious medical issue is discovered?
- Are you comfortable with the number of embryos we plan to transfer?
- What would you do if you developed a serious health complication?

ABOUT THE PREGNANCY RELATIONSHIP

- How much contact would you like during the pregnancy?
- Are you comfortable with us attending appointments?
- How do you feel about being present or having us present at the birth?
- What does post-birth contact look like for you?

ABOUT PRACTICAL MATTERS

- Are you comfortable with the reimbursement model and how expenses are managed?
- Are there any lifestyle restrictions that would be difficult for you to follow?
- Do you have reliable childcare during medical appointments?
- What does your support system look like during the pregnancy?

The Legal Agreement Deep-Dive

Your surrogacy agreement is the legal foundation of your journey. Every significant decision about the pregnancy should be addressed in it – before anything medical happens. Here is what must be covered.

IMPORTANT NOTICE

The agreement must be signed by all parties **before** any embryo transfer or medical procedure. This is non-negotiable. Any clinic operating with reputable practices will require confirmation that the agreement is in place before proceeding.

CLAUSE	WHAT IT COVERS
Identity of all parties	Full legal names, addresses, relationship status.
Roles and intentions	Clear statement that the IPs are the intended parents and the surrogate has no parental claim.
Medical decisions	Who makes medical decisions during the pregnancy. What happens in a medical emergency.
Selective reduction	Both parties' positions clearly documented.
Termination	Under what circumstances, if any, termination would be considered. Whose decision it is. What happens if parties disagree.
Number of embryos transferred	Agreed number per transfer.
Contact during pregnancy	Frequency, type, and boundaries of communication.
Appointment attendance	Which appointments IPs may attend.
Lifestyle expectations	Diet, travel, activities, substances.
Reimbursement schedule	All categories, amounts, submission process, payment timeline.

CLAUSE	WHAT IT COVERS
Insurance	Confirmation that life and disability insurance is in place.
Media and social media	Any restrictions on sharing information publicly.
Post-birth contact	Whether the parties intend to stay in touch, and in what way.
If the surrogate withdraws	Process, financial implications.
If the IPs withdraw	Process, financial implications.
Dispute resolution	How disagreements will be handled.
Governing jurisdiction	Which province's laws apply.

The Complete Budget Tracker

Use this section to build your actual budget. Fill in the "Your Budget" column as you confirm costs with each provider. The low and high estimates are realistic Canadian averages.

AGENCY AND PROGRAM FEES

COST CATEGORY	LOW EST.	HIGH EST.	YOUR BUDGET
Agency fee (Foundation / standard program)	\$9,500	\$21,500	
Agency fee (Priority / Fast Track program)	\$21,500	\$40,000	
Agency fee (Concierge / full service)	\$40,000	\$50,000+	
Independent journey admin and consultation	\$500	\$3,000	

SURROGATE REIMBURSEMENTS

COST CATEGORY	LOW EST.	HIGH EST.	YOUR BUDGET
Base monthly allowance (if applicable)	\$0	\$2,500/mo	
Maternity clothing	\$500	\$1,500	
Travel to appointments (mileage / transit)	\$1,500	\$5,000	
Lost wages for mandatory appointments	\$0	\$8,000	
Childcare during appointments	\$500	\$3,000	
Medications and supplements	\$1,000	\$4,000	
Psychological counselling	\$800	\$2,500	
Comfort items as agreed	\$500	\$1,500	
Miscellaneous approved expenses	\$1,000	\$3,000	
Surrogate Expenses Subtotal	~\$5,800	~\$30,500	

LEGAL FEES

COST CATEGORY	LOW EST.	HIGH EST.	YOUR BUDGET
IPs' surrogacy lawyer (agreement + parentage order)	\$5,000	\$12,000	
Surrogate's independent legal counsel (IPs pay)	\$1,500	\$4,000	
Additional legal fees (amendments, complications)	\$500	\$3,000	

MEDICAL AND FERTILITY COSTS

COST CATEGORY	LOW EST.	HIGH EST.	YOUR BUDGET
Fertility clinic fees (IVF / embryo creation)	\$8,000	\$20,000	
Embryo storage (annual)	\$500	\$1,500	
Surrogate medical screening	\$1,500	\$4,000	
Embryo transfer (per cycle)	\$3,000	\$8,000	
Psychological screening (both parties)	\$1,500	\$3,500	
OB/GYN care (if not fully covered by OHIP)	\$0	\$3,000	
Hospital delivery (if any costs not covered)	\$0	\$5,000	

INSURANCE AND MISCELLANEOUS

COST CATEGORY	LOW EST.	HIGH EST.	YOUR BUDGET
Surrogate life insurance (pregnancy term policy)	\$800	\$2,500	
Surrogate disability insurance	\$500	\$2,000	
Travel and accommodation (IPs to birth location)	\$500	\$5,000	
Post-birth legal (birth certificate, passport)	\$300	\$2,000	
Contingency / emergency fund (strongly recommended)	\$5,000	\$15,000	
Total Estimated Range (Canadian pathway)	~\$40,000 CAD	~\$140,000 CAD	

NOTE - US PATHWAY

If you pursue a U.S.-based surrogate through Camica or a U.S. agency, total costs typically run \$130,000 to \$200,000+ CAD due to surrogate compensation, U.S. medical costs, and legal

fees in both countries.

Clinic and Medical Guide

Choosing Your Fertility Clinic

Questions to ask before you commit:

- Do you work with surrogates? How many surrogate transfers do you do per year?
- What is your clinical pregnancy rate per transfer with gestational carriers?
- What does your surrogate screening process include?
- Can you receive embryos transferred from another clinic?
- What is your protocol for embryo transfer – medicated cycle, natural cycle?
- How many embryos do you recommend transferring?
- What are your fees for surrogate screening versus a standard IVF cycle?
- Do you require a psychological evaluation? Who do you recommend?

Medical Screening Process

SCREENING STEP	WHAT IT INVOLVES
Initial consultation	Review of medical history, previous pregnancies, current health.
Physical examination	General physical and gynaecological exam.
Bloodwork panel	Full CBC, metabolic panel, hormone levels, genetic carrier screening.
Infectious disease screening	HIV, hepatitis B and C, syphilis, CMV, and others. Partner must also be tested.
Uterine assessment	Sonohysterogram or hysteroscopy to assess uterine cavity.
Psychological evaluation	With a registered psychologist. Covers motivation, understanding, and mental health history.
Medical clearance letter	Formal written clearance from the clinic before legal agreements are signed.

The Embryo Transfer Process

PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS
Cycle preparation (2–4 weeks)	Surrogate takes estrogen to prepare the uterine lining. Monitored by ultrasound and bloodwork.
Lining check (Day 12–14)	Ultrasound confirms uterine lining is at target thickness. Transfer date confirmed.
Progesterone start (5–6 days before transfer)	Progesterone supplementation begins to prepare for implantation.
Transfer day	Embryo is thawed and transferred via thin catheter. Usually takes 15–30 minutes. No anaesthesia required.
Beta HCG test (10–12 days post-transfer)	Blood test confirms whether implantation occurred.
Second beta HCG (2 days later)	Confirms the number is rising appropriately.
First ultrasound (6–7 weeks)	Heartbeat confirmed. Transition to OB care begins.

The Pregnancy and Birth

First Trimester - Weeks 1 to 13

- **Weeks 1–4:** Beta HCG tests confirm pregnancy and rising levels.
- **Weeks 6–7:** First ultrasound. Heartbeat confirmed. This is a milestone to celebrate together.
- **Weeks 8–10:** Transition to OB/GYN care. Ensure IPs are added to the approved contact list.
- **Weeks 11–13:** First trimester screening (NIPT if desired, nuchal translucency ultrasound).

Second Trimester - Weeks 14 to 27

- **Weeks 14–16:** Second trimester begins. Miscarriage risk drops significantly.
- **Weeks 18–20:** Anatomy scan. IPs invited to attend if surrogate agrees.
- **Weeks 24–27:** Glucose tolerance test. Regular OB appointments continue.

Third Trimester and Birth Preparation - Weeks 28 to 40

- **Weeks 28–32:** Growth ultrasound. Group B strep test. Monthly appointments become bi-weekly.
- **Weeks 32–34:** IPs begin making travel arrangements. Pre-birth order filed with court (6–8 weeks before due date in applicable provinces).
- **Weeks 34–36:** Hospital notified of surrogacy arrangement. Birth plan filed. IPs confirmed on hospital access list.
- **Weeks 36–40:** Weekly appointments. IPs on standby near birth location.
- **Birth:** IPs present. Celebrate. Take photos. Cry. It is worth everything.

"To grieve is to know love. To hope is to begin again. And to hold your baby - however long the road took - is to know it was worth every step."

After the Birth

The baby is here. But the journey is not quite over. Here is what needs to happen in the weeks and months after birth.

STEP	TIMING	DETAILS
Register the birth	Within 30 days	Province-specific process.
Obtain parentage order (if not pre-birth)	Weeks 1–8 post-birth	Your lawyer files with the court.
Apply for birth certificate	After parentage confirmed	Usually 2–4 weeks.
Apply for Social Insurance Number	After birth certificate	At Service Canada.
Apply for passport (if travel required)	After birth certificate	Allow 6–8 weeks for standard processing.
Final expense reimbursements	Immediately post-birth	Process all outstanding receipts. Close the trust account.
Life insurance termination	After closing	Cancel surrogate's policy with her confirmation.
Post-journey check-in with surrogate	4–6 weeks post-birth	A call or note to acknowledge her contribution.
Legal file closure	Final step	Confirm with both lawyers that all matters are closed.

A NOTE ON THE RELATIONSHIP

How you close the journey with your surrogate matters. A handwritten note, a small gift, or simply a heartfelt phone call acknowledging what she gave your family – these things are

remembered. The families who maintain a gracious and grateful relationship at this stage consistently describe their surrogacy experience as one of the most meaningful of their lives.

Surrogate Match Interview Notes

Use this worksheet after each match meeting to record your observations and gut reactions. Fill in by hand or type directly.

SURROGATE'S NAME

DATE OF MEETING

LOCATION / FORMAT

HER MOTIVATION – WHY DOES SHE WANT TO BE A SURROGATE?

HER PREVIOUS PREGNANCY HISTORY

HER SUPPORT SYSTEM

HER VIEWS ON SELECTIVE REDUCTION AND TERMINATION

HER COMMUNICATION PREFERENCES AND EXPECTATIONS

QUESTIONS SHE ASKED US

HOW DID WE FEEL AFTER THE MEETING? (GUT CHECK)

DO WE WANT TO MOVE FORWARD? WHY OR WHY NOT?

Agency Comparison Tool

Compare up to three agencies side by side. Fill in after your consultation calls.

QUESTION	AGENCY A	AGENCY B	AGENCY C
How long have they been operating?			
How many surrogates apply monthly?			
Current average wait time to match?			
What is included in the agency fee?			
What is NOT included?			
How are surrogate expenses managed?			
Can they provide references?			
What happens if surrogate withdraws?			
Do they have surrogacy lawyers they recommend?			
Gut feeling about the team?			
Agency fee (total)			
Would we recommend them to a friend?			

Our Journey Goals and Intentions

Take your time with this one. Return to it throughout your journey.

WHY DO WE WANT TO BECOME PARENTS?

WHAT KIND OF RELATIONSHIP DO WE WANT WITH OUR SURROGATE?

WHAT DOES SUCCESS LOOK LIKE – BEYOND JUST A HEALTHY BABY?

WHAT ARE WE MOST AFRAID OF? (BE HONEST)

WHAT WILL WE DO TO SUPPORT EACH OTHER WHEN IT GETS HARD?

WHAT DO WE WANT TO TELL OUR CHILD ABOUT HOW THEY CAME TO BE?

ONE THING WE WANT TO REMEMBER ABOUT THIS JOURNEY, NO MATTER HOW IT GOES

Our Journey Budget Planner

Fill in your estimates before you begin, then track actuals as you go. Revisit this sheet at each phase of your journey.

COST ITEM	ESTIMATED (\$)	ACTUAL (\$)
Agency fee		
Surrogate monthly reimbursements (est. total)		
Surrogate travel and childcare (est.)		
Surrogate lost wages (est.)		
Surrogate life insurance		
Surrogate legal fees (your cost)		
Our surrogacy lawyer		
Fertility clinic (IVF / embryo creation)		
Surrogate medical screening		
Transfer cycle 1		
Transfer cycle 2 (if needed)		
Transfer cycle 3 (if needed)		
Psychological screening		
Our travel to birth location		
Post-birth legal (parentage, birth cert, passport)		
Contingency fund		
Other:		
Total		

REMINDER

\$60,000 CAD is the floor, not the ceiling. Build a contingency of at least \$10,000 to \$15,000 into your plan. Additional transfer cycles, complications, or provincial legal differences can add costs that are not always foreseeable at the outset.

WHAT COMES NEXT

You're Ready.

You have everything you need to move forward with clarity and confidence. This roadmap is yours to keep – come back to it at every phase of your journey.

If you would like support beyond what a guide can offer, Canadian Surrogacy Options is here. Whether that is a single consultation call, receipt management, or a full agency program – we meet you where you are.

BOOK YOUR FREE CALL

calendly.com/cso-robyn

30 minutes with Robyn – no obligation, no pressure.

Canadian Surrogacy Options
Cambridge & Guelph, Ontario
1-877-401-4175 | canadiansurrogacyoptions.com
robyn@canadiansurrogacyoptions.com

Little Miracles Egg Donation Services
little-miracles.ca

This guide is provided for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal or medical advice. Always obtain independent legal counsel before entering into any surrogacy arrangement. Laws vary by province – consult a surrogacy lawyer licensed in the relevant jurisdiction.